A Case Study of Involvement and Influence

Multi-year Cross-site Core Evaluation of the National Science Foundation's Collaboratives for Excellence in Teacher Preparation Program

Kelli Johnson
Frances Lawrenz
Lija Greenseid
University of Minnesota

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The Study

"Beyond Evaluation Use: *Determining the Effect of Project Participation on the Influence of NSF Program Evaluations"*

- Three-year NSF grant to study use, influence, and involvement within four NSF-funded programs
- Research team (2 co-PIs and 4 graduate students) based at the University of Minnesota
- Targeted case studies of four multi-site program evaluations

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The Context

The Collaboratives for Excellence in Teacher Preparation (CETP) Program

- NSF-funded, national program (1993-2000)
- 19 Collaboratives focused on improving STEM teacher preparation
- Each Collaborative involved 3-15 institutions of higher education and several school districts

The Challenge

To develop an overarching, program-level evaluation (the "Core") to document CETP accomplishments nationwide

- **BUT:** the Collaboratives would not be required to provide data to the Core – **all participation would be voluntary**
- **AND:** some of the Collaboratives had already developed their own project-level evaluations

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The Strategies

1. Carrots
   - funding
   - cleaned data
   - support
2. Collaborative planning meetings
3. In-depth instrument training
4. Some very small sticks

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The Results

- **Involvement:** Majority of project PIs and local evaluators reported at least some involvement in evaluation planning
- **Use/Influence:** Widespread perceived impact on knowledge, skills, and beliefs reported

In Conclusion

Involvement in the evaluation did not lead to greater cooperation in providing data, but…

Project leaders and evaluators reported

- Learning evaluation skills
- Broadening their perspectives on STEM education
- Feeling part of a network of Collaboratives

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Contact Information

Evaluation Use Team:

In alphabetical order:

Lija Greenseid
Kelli Johnson
Jean A. King
Frances Lawrenz
Stacie Toal
Boris Volkov

College of Education and Human Development
University of Minnesota
gree0573@umn.edu; (612) 625-0372

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